M.P.S. Aulakh (IPS 1970 Gujarat) held charge of the crucial post of assistant director at the Subsidiary Intelligence Bureau (SIB), Amritsar, from 1982 to 1985. In that capacity, he was in the know of Bhindranwale's day-to-day activities and related developments. A nephew of a close friend, Aulakh was known to me since his school days at Patiala. He recently told me that if the government wanted to abduct Bhindranwale and take him away to a predetermined place, it was not very difficult.

This was because Bhindranwale had a fixed routine of going on foot from the Akal Takht to the roof of the langar complex and returning the same way. He was always accompanied by eight to ten armed men, who would hang around him casually, without any apprehension of being attacked or arrested. If the day and time for such an operation had been carefully chosen (when there were fewer pilgrims in the complex), the number of civilian casualties could have been minimal. In fact, moderate Akali leaders and most of the general public of Punjab would have welcomed such a move, as they were getting sick of the continued instability in the state resulting from Bhindranwale's activities. [10]

Was Indira Gandhi's rejection of the SFF operation motivated only by her concern for civilian casualties, or was there was another reason, of which Nagrani was not aware? If one were to take this question a step further, would the abduction of Bhindranwale at this juncture have helped the Congress win the upcoming Lok Sabha elections? Actually, as per information obtained from the Punjab government through the ministry of home affairs by RTI activist Navdeep Gupta in 2017, till the day Bhindranwale died there was neither any actionable First Information Report (FIR) lodged against him nor any criminal case pending against him. Gupta is of the view that Bhindranwale's 'was basically a political murder.' Gupta's search for the truth behind Operation Blue Star continues, with a view to bringing the guilty to the court of justice. [11]

From the point of view of the 1 Akbar Road group, Bhindranwale had done the job for which his help had been enlisted. Bhindranwale alive and in detention at that time would have been a liability for the government. His arrest, even under the most dramatic circumstances, would not have ended militancy in Punjab.